The BJP has identified 144 Lok Sabha constituencies where it lost/ barely won in 2019 for special attention. The party deployed 25 Union ministers in these constituencies to do a SWOT analysis in the first phase, the next *pravas* starts in October. The majority of these borderline seats are in six states—Punjab, West Bengal, Maharashtra, UP, Bihar and Kerala. The others are spread across the country



MAHARASHTRA

LS Seats: **48**
BJP: **23**
Focus seats: **18**

STRATEGY
- Build BJP up as lone custodian of Hindutva politics
- Establish Eknath Shinde's rival Shiv Sena group as the real deal
- Restart pro-business projects

CHALLENGES
- An aggressive BJP may unite MVA allies
- Shinde faction of Shiv Sena still untested electorally
- Only two years of tenure left to turn around party's fortunes



KERALA

LS Seats: **20**
BJP: **0**
Focus seats: **5**

STRATEGY
- Working with Christian groups who have split with Congress
- Infuse new leadership in the state, especially in youth organisations

CHALLENGES
- RSS has deep network in the state, but unable to transfer votes to the BJP
- Party leaders, cadre not strong enough on the ground



WEST BENGAL

LS seats: **42**
BJP: **17**
Focus seats: **15**

STRATEGY
- Position BJP as only opposition to Mamata's TMC
- Take Hindutva, nationalism to rural areas
- Intensify *bhadralok* outreach in urban centres

CHALLENGES
- Exodus of turncoats may gain momentum
- Breakdown in organisational structure in various parts
- Factionalism in state unit



UP

LS Seats: **80**
BJP: **64**
Focus seats: **20**

STRATEGY
- Outreach to Jatav, Yadav communities (support base of BSP, SP respectively) and Jats
- Saturation coverage of central-sponsored schemes
- Build a 'controlled' Hindutva narrative

CHALLENGES
- No outreach plans for Muslims
- Anti-incumbency against second term party MPs

in its step after the sweep in Punjab. The BJP is hoping the new CM and a fresh cabinet will take the edge off the anti-incumbency. But leaving nothing to chance, it has been poaching Congress leaders with ground connections. Tribal leader Ashwin Kotwal is one such catch who fulfils BJP's outreach agenda and also weakens the Congress in north Gujarat. The party is still undecided on what to do with the other recruit from the Congress, Patidar leader Hardik Patel. Winning Gujarat, and winning it big, is crucial for PM Modi's grand plans to clinch 2024.

Meanwhile, Nadda's big focus is home state Himachal Pradesh. Factionalism is a bane here, and the party will need something extra special to buck the state trend of governments alternating every five years. Ex-CMs Prem Kumar Dhumal and Shanta Kumar still control factions and are said to be unhappy with being sidelined and with the new leaders—whether independents and ex-Congressmen—being inducted into the party.

The BJP's big battle in the south is in Karnataka, which goes to the polls in May 2023. It is aware that BSY's ouster from the CM's chair has not gone down well with the Lingayats, who make up 15 per cent of the electorate. Earlier in the year, central leaders had fobbed him off when he sought an MLC ticket for his younger son (elder son B.Y. Raghavendra is already an MP). Now that he sits on the party's parliamentary board, he should have more leverage. The party can't afford to get adventurous with the Yediyurappa family, which continues to wield substantial influence among Lingayats. The party is also hampered as the government is facing corruption allegations, and CM Bommai has been unable to motivate a weak administration. It needs the Lingayat seers onboard to have any chance of winning. Party sources also say the real power centre in the state is national general secretary (organisation) B.L. Santhosh. To keep the various warring groups in check, the party has appointed RSS pracharak Rajesh G.V. as Karnataka state general secretary (organisation) in late July, replacing Santhosh confidant Arun Kumar.

IN THE RUN-UP TO 2024, THE BJP IS CULTIVATING COMMUNITIES FOR WHOM THE PARTY IS NOT THE NATURAL CHOICE

BATTLE FOR THE HILLS

Tripura, along with Meghalaya and Nagaland, goes to the polls in February 2023. In the past four years, the Centre has used its good offices with the Sheikh Hasina government in Bangladesh to allow goods from West Bengal to be taken to Tripura through Bangladeshi territory rather than the clogged chicken neck, reducing travel time and accelerating development in the region. The BJP plans to project this as an example of "double engine" growth in the state. The Union government has also withdrawn draconian provisions from various places in Nagaland, with PM Modi promising to regularly review the situation on a recent visit to the Northeast. That said, the party will have no choice but to rely on its allies in the Northeast Democratic Alliance to better its electoral fortunes in Nagaland, Meghalaya, and later, in Mizoram. That, however, will remain a supplementary. ■